“Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta”

Antya-līlā

Chapter 18

Śrī Caitanya in the Waters of the Ocean

(translated from the Bengali for this edition)

1 Seeing the ocean in the light of the autumn moon, He took it for the Yamunā and ran into it. He plunged into it as if into an ocean of the burning pain of separation from Hari, lay unconscious in its waters the whole night, and at dawn was found by His own devotees. May that son of Śacī protect us here.

2 Glory, glory to Śrī Caitanya! Glory to Nityānanda! Glory to Advaitacandra, and glory to all the devotees of Gaura!

3 In this way Mahāprabhu lived in Nīlācala, floating night and day in the ocean of separation from Kṛṣṇa.

4 It was an autumn night, bright everywhere with moonlight, and the Lord wandered the whole night with His companions.

5 He wandered from garden to garden, watching wonders and reciting and hearing songs and verses about the *rāsa* dance.

6 Absorbed in love, the Lord sang and danced, and at times, absorbed in love, He enacted the *rāsa-līlā*.

7 Sometimes, in the madness of ecstatic feeling, the Lord ran here and there; sometimes He fell to the ground and swooned, and sometimes He

rolled about.

8 Whenever He recited or heard a verse about the *rāsa-līlā*, He Himself would explain its meaning, as before.

9 In this way He explained the meaning of every verse about the *rāsa-līlā*, feeling now joy, now sorrow.

10 To describe the meaning of all those verses and all those ecstatic transformations would make the book far too long.

11 For fear of making the book too long, I have not written down all the pastimes that took place moment by moment during those twelve years.

12 As I have only pointed out the direction before, so take this description of His ecstatic transformations and ravings.

13 Even if Ananta were to describe them with His thousand mouths, He could not reach the end of the pastimes of a single day.

14 Even if Gaṇeśa were to write for ten million ages, he could not come to the end of the pastimes of a single day.

15 Seeing the transformations of love in His devotee, even Kṛṣṇa is struck with wonder! When Kṛṣṇa Himself cannot find their end, what of anyone else, so insignificant?

16–17 Kṛṣṇa cannot fully know all the states of His devotee's love, its courses and its kinds, all its sorrow, all its happiness and all its transformations. So, to taste them, He accepts the mood of a devotee.

18 Love makes Kṛṣṇa dance and makes the devotee dance, and it dances itself: all three dance together in one place.

19 Whoever wants to describe the transformations of love is like a dwarf who wants to catch the moon.

20 As the wind carries off a single drop of the ocean's water, so a living being can touch only a drop of love for Kṛṣṇa.

21 Moment by moment endless waves of love rise up. How could an insignificant living being ever find their end?

22 What Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya tasted only Svarūpa and the others of His inner circle know.

23 If anyone, being an ordinary living being, describes it, he only touches a single drop of it, to purify himself.

24 In this way the Lord recited all the verses about the *rāsa* dance, and at the end He began to recite a verse about the water pastimes:

25 "Weary, Kṛṣṇa entered the water with the gopīs to relieve His fatigue, as a tired king of elephants, having broken through the dikes, enters the water with his she-elephants: for He too had passed beyond the bounds of worldly convention. Bees followed Him, singing like the lords of the Gandharvas, drawn by His garland, crushed by the contact of their bodies and reddened with the *kuṅkuma* from their breasts." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.33.22)

26 Wandering about in this way, Mahāprabhu suddenly saw the ocean from Āiṭoṭā.

27 The surging waves, bright in the moonlight, glittered like the waters of the Yamunā.

28 Taking it for the Yamunā, the Lord ran towards it and, unnoticed by anyone, leapt into the ocean.

29 As soon as He fell in, He swooned and knew nothing. The waves now sank Him beneath the water, now raised Him to the surface.

30 Carried by the waves, He drifted about like a dry log. Who can understand this drama of Caitanya?

31 The waves carried the Lord towards Koṇārka, sometimes keeping Him under the water, sometimes bearing Him along on the surface.

32 Kṛṣṇa was enjoying water pastimes with the gopīs in the Yamunā, and Mahāprabhu was absorbed in that play.

33 Here, not seeing the Lord, Svarūpa and the others were startled and said, "Where has the Lord gone?"

34 The Lord had gone with the speed of the mind, and they could not see Him go. Not seeing Him, they began to wonder:

35 "Has He gone to the temple to see Jagannātha? Or has He fallen down somewhere in another garden, in His madness?

36 Has He gone to the Guṇḍicā temple, or to Narendra Lake? To Caṭaka-parvata, or to Koṇārka?"

37 Saying this, they all went about looking for the Lord, and then came to the seashore, taking a few others with them.

38 As they wandered about searching like this, the night came to an end, and they concluded, "The Lord has departed."

39 In separation from the Lord they all felt as if life had left their bodies, and no one could think of anything but the fear that some harm had come to Him.

40 “The hearts of those who love always fear some harm.” (Abhijñāna-śakuntala, 4)

41 Coming to the seashore, they took counsel together, and some of them went towards Cirāyu-parvata (Caṭaka-parvata).

42 Svarūpa went east with a few others, searching for the Lord along the shore and in the waters of the sea.

43 They were all overwhelmed with grief and hardly conscious, yet, moved by love, they kept wandering in search of the Lord.

44 Then they saw a fisherman coming along with his net on his shoulder. He was laughing, weeping, dancing and singing, and saying, “Hari! Hari!”

45 Everyone was astonished to see how the fisherman was behaving, and Svarūpa Gosāñi asked him what had happened:

46 “Tell us, fisherman, have you seen someone around here? And why are you in such a state? Tell us the reason.”

47 The fisherman said, “I have not seen a single person here. But as I was drawing in my net, a dead body came into it.

48 Thinking it was a big fish, I hauled it up with great effort, but when I saw the corpse my heart was filled with fear.

49 As I was freeing the net, I touched his body, and at that very touch the spirit entered my heart.

50 I began to tremble with fear, tears flowed from my eyes, my voice choked, and all my hair stood on end.

51 Whether it is a *brahma-daitya* or a spirit, I cannot say, but the moment anyone sees it, it enters his body.

52 His body is long — five or seven cubits — and each of his arms and legs is three cubits long.

53 The joints of his bones have come loose, and his skin hangs slack. Who could see that and not have the life frightened out of him?

54 He lies there like a corpse, his eyes turned upward. Sometimes he makes a sound — "goṅ, goṅ" — and sometimes I see him lying unconscious.

55 I have seen him with my own eyes, and that spirit has seized me. If I die, how will my wife and children live?

56 That spirit is beyond describing. I am going to an exorcist — perhaps he can drive the spirit out.

57 I wander alone at night, catching fish in lonely places, yet spirits and ghosts do not touch me, because I remember Nṛsiṁha.

58 But at the name of Nṛsiṁha this spirit presses on me twice as hard. The mere sight of his form fills my mind with fear.

59 Do not go there — I forbid you! If you go there, that spirit will seize you all."

60 Hearing this, Svarūpa Gosāñi understood the whole truth and spoke some very sweet words to the fisherman:

61 "I am a great exorcist; I know how to drive out spirits." Reciting a mantra, he placed his holy hand on the fisherman's head.

62 Giving him three slaps, he said, “The spirit has fled. Do not be afraid!” — and so he calmed him.

63 Love on the one hand and fear on the other had made him doubly restless. Now that the fear was gone, he grew somewhat calmer.

64 Svarūpa said, “The one you take for a spirit is no spirit at all. He is Kṛṣṇa Caitanya, the Supreme Lord.

65 Absorbed in love, He fell into the sea, and you hauled Him up in your net.

66 By His touch love for Kṛṣṇa awoke in you, but because you thought He was a spirit or a ghost, you were terribly afraid.

67 Now the fear has gone, and your mind is calm. Show me where you hauled Him up.”

68 The fisherman said, “I have seen the Lord many times. That is not Him — this one has a terribly distorted form.”

69 Svarūpa said, “Transformations of love arise in Him. The joints of His bones come apart, and His body becomes very long.”

70 Hearing this, the fisherman was delighted. He took them all along and showed them Mahāprabhu.

71 He was lying on the ground, His whole body elongated, white from the water and covered with sand.

72 His body was very long and slack, and its skin hung loose. It was impossible to lift Him and carry Him so far.

73 They removed His wet loincloth and dressed Him in a dry one, brushed off the sand and laid Him on His outer cloth.

74 Then all of them together began loud *saṅkīrtana*, chanting the name of Kṛṣṇa loudly into the Lord's ear.

75 After some time the sound reached the Lord's ears, and with a loud cry He at once rose up.

76 As soon as He rose, all His bones returned to their places. Half-conscious of the outer world, He looked about here and there.

77 Mahāprabhu was always in one of three states: the internal state, the external state, and the half-external.

78 When something of the absorption of the internal state remains along with some external awareness, the devotees call that state "half-external."

79 In the half-external state the Lord spoke in ravings. He spoke as if to the sky, and the devotees listened:

80 "Seeing the Kālindī, I went to Vṛndāvana, and I see the son of the king of Vraja playing in the water.

81 Together with Rādhikā and the other gopīs, He is playing in the waters of the Yamunā with great delight.

82 Standing on the bank with the *sakhīs*, I watch, and one *sakhī* points out that play to the others.

83 Handing their silk garments and ornaments over to the *sakhīs* and dressed in fine white cloth, Kṛṣṇa entered the water with His beloveds and arranged beautiful water pastimes.

84 O *sakhī*, see the play of Kṛṣṇa's water pastimes! Kṛṣṇa is like a maddened lord of elephants; His lotus hands are restless, and the gopīs are His companions.

85 The water play began. They splashed water at one another; there was a tumult, and water rained down in streams. No one could tell who was winning and who was losing, and the water battle grew boundless.

86 The steady flashes of lightning rained water on the dark new cloud, and the cloud rained upon the lightning. The eyes of the *sakhīs*, like thirsty *cātakī* birds, drank that nectar with joy.

87 First they fought water against water, then hand against hand, after that face to face, then heart to heart; then came a battle of words, and then a battle of nails.

88 With a thousand hands He sprinkled water, with a thousand eyes He looked at the gopīs, with a thousand feet He drew near them, with a thousand mouths He kissed them, with a thousand bodies He embraced them, and with a thousand ears He heard the gopīs' playful jests.

89 Kṛṣṇa took Rādhā by force into water up to His neck and left Her where the water was fathomless. Clasping Kṛṣṇa's neck, She floated on the water like a lotus plant uprooted by an elephant.

90 Assuming as many forms as there were beautiful cowherd girls, Kṛṣṇa took away all their garments. In the clear water of the Yamunā their bodies shimmered, and Kṛṣṇa beheld them with joy.

91 The lotus creepers, like a host of *sakhīs*, came to the help of some of them, placing leaves in their hands. Some let down their hair and made it a lower garment in front, and some made a bodice of their hands.

92 When Kṛṣṇa began a quarrel with Rādhā, the gopīs at once went to hide among the golden lotuses. They sank into the water up to their necks, so that only their faces floated on the surface, and one could not tell the faces from the lotuses.

93 Here Kṛṣṇa did with Rādhā as He had wished, and then went to look for the gopīs. Then subtle-minded Rādhā, knowing where Her *sakhīs* were, came and joined them.

94 As many golden lotuses as floated on the water, so many blue lotuses came up beside them and met them. Blue lotus struck against golden lotus, each one in battle, and the *sakhīs* watched from the bank with amusement.

95 A flock of *cakravāka* birds rose from the water, pair by pair. Then a cluster of lotuses rose, pair by pair, and covered the *cakravākas*.

96 Then many red water lilies (*utpala*) rose, pair by pair, and warded off the lotuses. The lotuses wanted to carry off the *cakravākas* as plunder, and the water lilies wanted to protect them; so for the sake of the *cakravākas* the two fought.

97 Lotuses and water lilies are insentient, while *cakravākas* are sentient; yet here the lotuses taste the *cakravākas*. The positions of the two are reversed, and their natures have turned into their opposites: such is the rule in Kṛṣṇa’s kingdom.

98 The lotus comes and plunders the *cakravāka*, its neighbour and the friend of its own friend, the sun — such is the way in Kṛṣṇa’s kingdom. And the water lily protects the friend of its enemy, though it does not even know him — a great wonder! This is the great ornament called “contradiction” (*virodha*).

99 Thus Kṛṣṇa openly displayed two figures of speech, hyperbole (*atiśayokti*) and apparent contradiction (*virodhābhāsa*). As I tasted them, My mind was delighted, and My eyes and ears were refreshed.

100 After such wonderful play Śrī Hari came up onto the bank with all His beloveds, and there the *sakhīs* served Them, massaging Them with fragrant oil and rubbing Them with *āmalakī* paste.

101 Then They bathed again, put on dry clothes and came to a jewelled house. There, with the fragrances, flowers and ornaments Vṛndā had prepared, They were dressed in forest attire.

102 The trees and creepers of Vṛndāvana are wonderful indeed: all twelve months of the year they bear flowers and fruits. The goddesses of Vṛndāvana and all the maidservants of the bowers picked the fruits and brought them.

103 Preparing the fruits with great care, they filled large platters with them and set them out in rows on a raised dais in the jewelled house, in the order in which they were to be eaten, with seats in front to sit on.

104 There were coconuts of many kinds and mangoes of many sorts, bananas and jujubes of various kinds, jackfruits, dates, oranges, tangerines, *jāma* fruits, pomelos (*sāntārā*), grapes, almonds, and all kinds of dried fruits and nuts.

105 Melons, *kṣīrikā* cucumbers, palm fruits, *keśura* roots, water chestnuts, lotus stalks, *bilva*, *pīlu*, pomegranates and many more — whatever fruit is famous in any land is found in Vṛndāvana. There are a thousand kinds; how many can be written down?

106 *Gaṅgājala*, *amṛtakeli*, *pīyūṣagranthi*, *karpūrakeli*, *sarapūrī*, *amṛti*, *padmacini*, and little trees made of sugar and *kṣīrisāra* — all

these various sweets Rādhā had made at home and brought for Kṛṣṇa.

107 Seeing the fine arrangement of the food, Kṛṣṇa was very happy, and He sat down to the forest meal. Then Rādhā ate with Her *sakhīs*, and the two of Them lay down to rest in the house.

108 Someone fanned Them, someone massaged Their feet, someone gave Them betel to chew. Rādhā and Kṛṣṇa fell asleep, and the *sakhīs* lay down too. My heart was happy to see it.

109 Just then you all seized Me, made a great uproar and brought Me here. Where is the Yamunā now, where is Vṛndāvana? Where are Kṛṣṇa and the gopīs? You have broken My happiness!”

110 As He said this, the Lord came fully back to external consciousness. Seeing Svarūpa Gosāñi, He asked him,

111 “Why have you brought Me here?” Then Svarūpa Gosāñi began to speak:

112 “Taking the ocean for the Yamunā, You fell into it, and the waves of the ocean carried You this far!

113 This fisherman hauled You up in his net, and by Your touch he became mad with love.

114 All night long we wandered about searching for You. Hearing from the fisherman, we came here and found You.

115 Under the guise of a swoon You watch pastimes in Vṛndāvana, but seeing You swoon, we all suffer at heart.

116 When we chanted the name of Kṛṣṇa, You came to half-external consciousness, and we heard the ravings You spoke in that state.”

117 The Lord said, “In a dream I saw that I went to Vṛndāvana, and I see Kṛṣṇa dancing the *rāsa* with the gopīs.

118 After the water pastimes He enjoyed a forest meal. It seems to Me that, seeing this, I spoke in ravings.”

119 Then Svarūpa Gosāñi bathed the Lord and, overjoyed, brought Him home.

120 Thus I have told of the Lord’s fall into the ocean. Whoever hears this attains the feet of Caitanya.

121 Praying at the feet of Śrī Rūpa and Śrī Raghunātha, I, Kṛṣṇadāsa, narrate the *Caitanya-caritāmṛta*.